

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

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Amos 1:1

message (literally *words*): This standard way of introducing a prophetic message ([Jer 1:1](#); see also [Hag 1:12](#)) emphasizes its form and content. • shepherd (Hebrew *noqed*): This word is used just one other time in the Old Testament, to describe the king of Moab as a “sheep breeder” ([2 Kgs 3:4](#)). Amos describes his vocation in [Amos 7:14](#) using a different Hebrew word (*boqer*, which means “herder”; see Amos Book Introduction, “The Prophet Amos”). Amos was not a professional prophet serving the court or the Temple. • Amos received this message in visions—that is, by divine revelation (see [Isa 1:1](#)). • Amos depicts the earthquake that occurred during the reign of Uzziah ([Zech 14:5](#)) as an act of God’s judgment ([Amos 3:14–15](#); [6:11, 14](#); [8:8](#); [9:1, 9](#)). • Uzziah, also called Azariah (792–740 BC), was the most powerful king of Judah after the division of the kingdom. • Jeroboam II (793–753 BC), who descended from the dynasty of Jehu, took advantage of a power vacuum in the region and recovered territory earlier lost to the Arameans.

Amos 1:2

This message speaks of judgment at the day of the Lord. • Mount Zion (the Temple in Jerusalem) was the logical source of a message from the Lord. • Mount Carmel rises from the Mediterranean Sea and is well watered even in time of drought. If all the grass on Mount Carmel withered, it would be the sign of a catastrophic drought.

Amos 1:3

have sinned again and again: Literally *have committed three sins, even four*. This expression is used for a repeated act of rebellion against the natural order established by God. The Hebrew phrase does not denote a strict count but a pattern of repeated violations. • beat down my people: Threshing grain involved separating the heads of the grain from their hulls by pulling wooden sledges with sharp teeth over the cut grain ([Isa 41:15](#); see [Mic 4:13](#)). This description provides a

graphic picture of the brutality of the people of Damascus.

Amos 1:3–5

Damascus, the capital of Aram, was brutal in its treatment of the people of Gilead, Israel’s territory east of the Jordan. By the time Ahab died (853 BC), Damascus had captured Ramoth in Gilead ([1 Kgs 22:3](#)). Around 801 BC, Assyria captured Damascus, and the city never again held the power it had wielded in its prime.

Amos 1:3–2.16

The eight judgments of this prophecy proceed from the most obvious enemy, Damascus, to the least obvious, Israel itself. The sequence would have engaged Israel’s attention as they heard God’s judgment against their enemies, but Amos eventually confronted the people with God’s judgment on them.

Amos 1:4

I will send down fire: In ancient times conquered cities were burned by invading armies (see also [1:7, 10, 12, 14](#); [2:2, 5](#)). The conquest of Damascus would be God’s judgment on them. • Hazael reigned as king of Damascus (about 843–802 BC) after he seized the throne by assassination. Ben-hadad was Hazael’s son and successor (about 802–792 BC).

Amos 1:5

Aven and Beth-eden were both connected with Aram and Damascus. Aven (meaning *evil, wickedness*) refers to the valley between the Lebanon and Anti-Lebanon mountains or the plain of Damascus. The city-state Beth-eden was north of Aram, elsewhere simply called *Eden* ([2 Kgs 19:12](#); [Ezek 27:23](#)). • The Arameans originally came from Kir ([Amos 9:7](#)), probably in southern Babylonia; Kir was where Assyria deported them when Damascus fell ([2 Kgs 16:9](#)). Just as Egypt was a

symbol of captivity for Israel (see [Deut 28:68](#)), Kir represented captivity for Aram.

Amos 1:6

The Philistine city of Gaza, on the seacoast at the southwest edge of Palestine, was the gateway for traffic between Africa and Asia. Its sin was slave trading; Philistia had raided Israel or Judah and sold whole villages into slavery to Edom.

Amos 1:7

I will send down fire: Uzziah conquered Philistia ([2 Chr 26:6](#)); in 701 BC, the Assyrian invasion all but ended the distinct identity of the Philistines.

Amos 1:8

The Philistine cities of Ashdod and Ashkelon were on or near the seacoast, while Ekron lay inland. Gath is not mentioned here, as it had been conquered earlier by Hazael ([2 Kgs 12:17](#)) and then Uzziah ([2 Chr 26:6](#)). • the few Philistines still left: The Philistines maintained their ethnic identity through the Assyrian period, but this distinction faded by the time of the Persians ([Zech 9:5-7](#)).

Amos 1:9

Tyre and Sidon were the principal seaports of Phoenicia. • Tyre's crime, like Philistia's ([1:6-8](#)), was selling whole villages of Israelite captives to the Edomites as slaves, a captivity made more bitter by a sense of betrayal (see [2 Sam 5:11](#); [1 Kgs 5:1, 11](#); [16:30-31](#)). Tyre's reputation was "anything is for sale"; Isaiah portrayed the city as a prostitute peddling her wares ([Isa 23:15-17](#)).

Amos 1:10

fire on the walls: The main part of Tyre was built on an island, making it almost impossible to capture (see [Ezek 26:1-28:19](#)).

Amos 1:11

Edom was another betrayer (see [1:9](#); [Gen 36](#); see also [Gen 25:23-30](#); [27:39-40](#)). • The NLT adds the Israelites to make explicit what relatives (literally *brother*) means (see [Gen 25:25-30](#)). "Brothers" can also refer to parties to a treaty (see [Amos 1:9](#)). Apparently Edom exerted constant pressure on the borders of Israel and Judah, raiding and plundering at moments of weakness ([Jer 49:7-22](#); [Obad 1:1-9](#)).

Amos 1:12

With the destruction of the major cities of Teman and Bozrah, Edom lost its capacity for continual warfare. Babylon destroyed Edom shortly after Judah in 553 BC (see [Jer 27](#); [49:7-22](#); see also study note on [Obad 1:18](#)).

Amos 1:13

Israel regarded the people of Ammon as kin who also betrayed them. The Ammonites (like the Moabites, [2:1](#)) were descendants of Lot, Abraham's nephew ([Gen 19:37-38](#)). Ammon had been a constant threat to Gilead (see [Judg 10:7-9](#)). • In ancient times, conquering armies commonly ripped open pregnant women ([2 Kgs 8:12](#); [15:16](#); [Hos 13:16](#)); they also raped the women and slaughtered the children of the towns they seized ([Isa 13:16, 18](#); [Lam 5:11](#); [Hos 10:14](#); [13:16](#); [Nah 3:10](#); [Zech 14:2](#)).

Amos 1:14

Rabbah was the chief city of the Ammonites ([2 Sam 12:26](#)). • Ammon ([Amos 1:13](#)) was crushed by the Assyrians in the 800s BC, then attacked and depopulated by the Babylonians in the 700s.

Amos 1:15

their king: The Hebrew term *malkam* may be a reference to the Ammonite god Molech. In ancient times, people believed that a conquered nation's god or gods went into exile together with them (see [5:26-27](#); [1 Sam 5:1-2](#); [Isa 46:1](#)).

Amos 2:1

desecrated the bones: In some past skirmish, the Moabites had captured Edom's king. Cremation was considered a form of desecration; if the ashes (literally *lime*) of the king were used in plaster, the insult would be compounded.

Amos 2:2-3

Kerioth, a major town ([Jer 48:20-24](#)), is mentioned on the Moabite Stone as a shrine to Chemosh, Moab's god. Perhaps the Moabites burned the remains of Edom's king or offered him as a human sacrifice at this site. Because of the desecration of the Edomite king's corpse, God would destroy the king of Moab and his officers. This fate probably came upon them through an invasion by Sargon II of Assyria (715/713 BC; cp. [Isa 15-16](#)). Josephus (*Antiquities* 10.9.7) implies a further destruction in 582 BC (see also [Jer 48](#); [Ezek 25:8-11](#); [Zeph 2:8-11](#)).

Amos 2:4

rejected the instruction (Hebrew torah) of the Lord: The pagan nations listed to this point had committed atrocities that violated a general sense of human decency, but Judah had gone further; they held the word of God and yet had rejected its teachings (see [Hos 4:6](#); [8:1](#)). God holds people responsible in proportion to the privilege they have received (see [Amos 3:2](#)). • led astray by the same lies: Having discarded God's true instruction, Judah turned to a substitute found in pagan syncretism (the combining of elements from different belief systems) and idolatry (see [1 Kgs 14:22-24](#)).

Amos 2:4-5

The southern kingdom of Judah was closest to the northern kingdom of Israel in blood ties and geography, but bitterness existed between the nations. The north regarded the descendants of David in the south as abusive kings who had caused the schism by their forced labor and heavy taxes.

Amos 2:5

Judah's paganism brought the same punishment as the sins of its pagan neighbors: fire ([1:4](#), [7](#), [10](#), [12](#), [14](#); [2:2](#)) that would destroy Jerusalem. The Babylonians burned Jerusalem when they captured it in 586 BC (see [2 Kgs 25:9](#); [Neh 2:17](#); [4:2](#)).

Amos 2:6

Honorable people are the "righteous," those who enjoyed a right relationship with God and other people. The parallel with poor people creates the idea of the "righteous needy." The law of Moses urged those who had much to help those in need by lending freely ([Deut 15:7-11](#)). As a last resort, those too poor to pay their debts could become bond servants to repay their debts through labor ([Lev 25:39-43](#)). These righteous needy were being sold into bond servitude for a pair of sandals, a hyperbole for the pittance they owed (see [Amos 8:6](#)). The sandals were a pledge given for the debt or a token used to seal a bargain (see [Ruth 4:7](#)).

Amos 2:6-16

Israel: After leading the people through a litany of sins committed by Israel's neighbors, Amos arrived at his real point: The Israelites would suffer a similar fate (cp. Nathan's use of prophetic rhetoric to induce self-indictment, [2 Sam 12:1-13](#)).

Amos 2:7

To trample . . . people was to treat them ruthlessly (see also [8:4](#)). • The helpless and oppressed were people exploited by a socio-economic system that denied them the justice guaranteed by law ([Exod 23:6-8](#)). • That father and son sleep with the same woman demonstrated the moral destitution of the Israelites; the law of Moses prohibited this practice ([Lev 18:7-8](#), [15](#); [20:11-12](#)). • corrupting my holy name: In worshiping various fertility gods, Israel and surrounding nations engaged in "sacred prostitution" (see [Hos 4:10-14](#)). Sexual relations with a shrine prostitute were thought to ensure plentiful crops and thriving herds of livestock. This verse suggests that these acts were performed in the name of the Lord. When performed as religious rituals, these corrupt actions treat God's name as worthless.

Amos 2:8

The irony is that the oppressors of the poor flaunted their sins at religious festivals. • The Torah allowed a lender to take a poor man's cloak as security for a debt, but it was not to be kept overnight, because the nights were cold ([Exod 22:26-27](#); [Deut 24:12-13](#)). A widow's clothing was never to be taken as security for a debt ([Deut 24:17](#)). • unjust fines: The wealthy bribed judges and used their influence to keep the poor, who could not defend themselves, from obtaining a fair hearing ([Amos 5:12](#)).

Amos 2:9

Amorites is used here as a general term to denote the inhabitants of Canaan (see [Gen 15:16](#); [Judg 6:10](#)).

Amos 2:11-12

In addition to priests, God provided prophets to speak his word and will ([Deut 18:15-19](#)) and holy men called Nazirites, who were dedicated to the Lord by vows that included abstention from fermented drinks ([Num 6:1-21](#)). Israel showed its disregard for God by telling both the Nazirites and the prophets to ignore and violate God's calling (see [Amos 7:12-13](#)).

Amos 2:14-16

The chapter concludes with a description of the battle in which Israel would be defeated and would flee (see [Ps 33:16-17](#)).

Amos 2:15

The archers stood in the last ranks. If they fled, it meant the forward ranks had collapsed.

Amos 2:16

Amos later calls that day the "day of the Lord" ([5:18](#)); both expressions indicate the time of judgment on Israel (see also [8:3](#)).

Amos 3:1

Amos begins with a reference to God's goodness to Israel when he rescued them from Egypt (see [2:10](#)).

Amos 3:1-2

The first message from the Lord warns Israel that its status as God's elect will not excuse them from God's judgment. Instead, they will be held to a higher standard than the surrounding nations.

Amos 3:1-5.17

Amos directs the three prophetic messages in this section against Israel, indicting them for a false understanding of their status as God's chosen people. The messages show a progression toward judgment.

Amos 3:2

The word translated been intimate indicates personal and experiential knowledge that often extends beyond mere intellectual awareness. It can indicate formal recognition and acknowledgment ([Exod 1:8](#); [5:2](#)), personal experience ([Gen 2:17](#)), or sexual relations ([Gen 4:1](#)). This word is frequently used of God's relationship with Israel ([Hos 5:3](#)) and of Israel's ideal relationship with God ([Hos 2:20](#)). Because of Israel's privileged status, God would hold them accountable for all their sins, not just some of them. God holds people accountable in terms of what has been given them ([Luke 12:47-48](#)).

Amos 3:3

Amos's walk with God was evidence that his message was in accord with the direction of God's plans for Israel's judgment.

Amos 3:3-6

Amos explains his call to prophesy with a series of rhetorical questions that must be answered in the negative. But the metaphorical language carries

deeper meaning than is implied in the questions themselves.

Amos 3:4

Amos's messages have God behind them: What he says would, in fact, happen to Israel. God is the lion who roars, and he has already found his victim—the people of Israel who are ready for judgment.

Amos 3:5

The trap pictures the consequences of Israel's sin. Israel fully deserved the judgment that Amos proclaimed.

Amos 3:6

disaster . . . the Lord has planned: God sends both the good and pleasant, and the harmful and painful ([Isa 45:7](#); [Lam 3:38](#); see [Deut 28](#); [Job 2:10](#)).

Amos 3:8

God, the lion, has roared from Mount Zion ([1:2](#)) and compelled Amos to prophesy (see [7:14–16](#)).

Amos 3:9

The prophet now turns to two of Israel's enemies, Philistia (Hebrew *Ashdod*, one of the key cities of Philistia) and Egypt. He invites them to surround Samaria (the capital of the kingdom of Israel) to see its chaos and oppression. Israel appeared strong from the outside, but it was rotten within, rife with class struggles. The enemies would take advantage of Israel's internal weakness (see [3:11](#)).

Amos 3:10

Israel's rich people acquired their wealth through their neglect and brutal treatment of the poor and helpless (see [2:6–8](#)).

Amos 3:11

The real enemy was not Egypt or Philistia, but Assyria, the only superpower in the region.

Amos 3:12

A shepherd who tries to rescue: The people of both Israel and Judah believed that, because of their chosen status, God would intervene to rescue them and never let them perish. The prophet's words are ironic: Their rescue would be like a shepherd who arrives too late to save the sheep, and who can pull only two legs or a piece of an ear from the mouth of the lion. • So it will be . . . reclining on couches: Some have interpreted this statement to mean that only the fabric of a few couches would survive the Assyrian siege of Samaria. Accordingly, the last two lines of this verse could be translated *So it will be when the Israelites in Samaria are rescued / with only a broken bed and a tattered pillow*.

Amos 3:13

The Lord's message is to go to all Israel (literally *the house of Jacob*). Jacob was the ancestor of both Israel and Judah. • The witnesses who are told to listen could be the nations summoned in [3:9](#), the inhabitants of Samaria, or bands of prophets. • Lord God of Heaven's Armies: This title, traditionally "Lord God of Hosts" (also in [4:13](#); [5:14–16](#), [27](#); [6:8](#)), portrays God as commander of the heavenly armies; this is the true God of the universe, not a local deity (see also [Exod 15:3](#)).

Amos 3:14

pagan altars at Bethel: The shrine at Bethel, built by Jeroboam I shortly after his inauguration ([1 Kgs 12:26–33](#)), continued through the dynasty of Jehu ([2 Kgs 10:29](#)), from whom Jeroboam II descended. This shrine merged worship of Yahweh (the Lord) with the pagan symbol of a bull. When the altars were destroyed, the Bethel shrine, the king's official sanctuary ([Amos 7:13](#)), and the northern kingdom would also be ruined.

Amos 3:15

Ivory represents the immense, ill-gotten wealth of the rich. Archaeologists have found some of these ivory inlays in the ruins of Samaria.

Amos 4:1

you fat cows (literally *you cows of Bashan*): Bashan was famous for its fierce, fat bulls ([Ps 22:12](#); [Ezek 39:18](#)). Amos uses the feminine form (cows) to paint a picture of Israel's upper class wives, who cared little for the poor. Their only concern was to extract enough wealth from the needy to support their own consumption.

Amos 4:1–3

In this message Amos holds Samaria's wives accountable for urging their husbands to perform ruthless acts in order to provide them with money for their parties.

Amos 4:2

has sworn this by his holiness: Holiness speaks of God as existing outside of and independent of creation; his nature is wholly other than what he has created. The oath is similar to [6:8](#); [8:7](#). • hooks: The Assyrians were known for their inhumane treatment of war captives (see [2 Chr 33:11](#); cp. [2 Kgs 19:28](#)). A stela (stone pillar with an inscription) discovered in northern Syria shows the Assyrian king Esarhaddon holding cords that pass through the lips of two war captives. A recent scholar has suggested that *hooks* referred to the rings inserted into the noses of cattle to manage them.

Amos 4:3

The wall of Samaria that these women trusted for security could not protect them.

Amos 4:4

Amos lampoons the Israelites' worthless piety. • Bethel, the site of Jacob's famous vision of the ladder with angels descending and ascending ([Gen](#)

[28:11–22](#)), was the southern seat of the religion established by Jeroboam I (see [Amos 3:14](#); [1 Kgs 12:28–29](#)). Gilgal, Israel's campsite after they crossed the Jordan ([Josh 4:19–5:9](#)), had become a popular shrine by the time of Amos and Hosea ([Hos 4:15](#); [9:15](#); [12:11](#)). • sacrifices each morning . . . tithes every three days: Israelite males were to appear before the Lord at the sanctuary three times each year ([Exod 23:14–19](#); [34:23](#); [Deut 16:16–17](#)). Tithes were typically paid annually ([Deut 14:22–29](#)), with a special tithe paid every three years (see [Deut 14:28](#); [26:12](#)). Amos is making the point that the Israelites were religious to the point of absurdity, but they balked at being godly ([Amos 5:15](#); [Hos 6:6](#); [Mic 6:8](#); see [Luke 11:42](#)).

Amos 4:4–5

The prophet's sarcasm shows how far Israel had strayed from God's ways. Israel had plenty of religion but no reverence for God.

Amos 4:5

Leavened bread (that is, sourdough fermented by wild yeast) was for daily consumption. The more primitive unleavened bread (made without yeast) became a sacred symbol, commemorating Israel's affliction as slaves in Egypt ([Deut 16:3](#)), the Passover ([Exod 12:17–20](#)), and their hasty departure from that land ([Exod 12:34, 39](#)). Unleavened bread thus became altar bread ([Lev 6:17](#); [7:12](#)). However, bread made with yeast could accompany a peace offering of thanksgiving ([Lev 7:13](#)).

Amos 4:6–11

God sent natural disasters to bring his people to repentance, but each time they failed to respond in any sincere manner. Amos ends the account of each disaster with the refrain, "But still you would not return to me," says the Lord.

Amos 4:10

God had used plagues to convince Egypt to let Israel go ([Exod 7:14–12:30](#); [9:2–3](#); [Ps 91:6](#); [Hab 3:5](#)); he promised to bring the plagues of Egypt on Israel if

they continued to turn away from him to worship pagan gods ([Deut 28:27, 60](#)).

Amos 4:11

As with the plagues on Egypt ([4:10](#)), the plagues on Israel increased in magnitude and intensity (cp. [4:12](#)). • as I destroyed: The thought that God would treat his own people in the same way as he had treated Sodom and Gomorrah ([Gen 19:24-25](#)) was shocking to their theology.

Amos 4:12

This is one of the two great thematic verses in Amos (the second is [5:24](#)). Since Israel would not repent, it must meet . . . God in judgment.

Amos 4:13

This verse appears to be a hymn fragment, possibly sung by the worshipers at Bethel (for other hymn fragments, see [5:8-9](#); [9:5-6](#)). Israel had been treating God as a *baal*—a local god with limited power. But the God they professed to worship and whom they would face in judgment is all-powerful.

Amos 5:1

funeral song: The Hebrew word (qinah) describes a special rhythm (3+2 beats) used for funeral dirges (most of the book of Lamentations is written in qinah). The ominous significance was clear: Israel had already died and now awaited burial.

Amos 5:1-3

The charges against Israel had been filed ([3:1-2](#); [4:1-3](#)); now it was time for judgment. Amos made this point clear by singing a funeral song for Israel, as though the nation were already dead.

Amos 5:2

When used to describe political powers, virgin refers to a state of being unconquered by a foreign

power (e.g., Babylon, [Isa 47:1](#); Jerusalem, [Lam 2:13](#); cp. [Lam 1:1](#)).

Amos 5:3

This verse is a reversal of the promises made in [Lev 26:8](#).

Amos 5:4

Come back to me and live implies a condition: In order to live, Israel should seek the Lord (also in [5:6](#)). Otherwise, the funeral song ([5:1-2](#)) would become Israel's death sentence.

Amos 5:5

Beersheba was another site (see study note on 4:4) with ties to the patriarchal era (e.g., Abraham, [Gen 21:33](#); [22:19](#)) that had been made into a shrine. • Gilgal . . . exile: A wordplay using alliteration (Hebrew *hagilgal galoh yigleh*).

Amos 5:6

The northern kingdom of Israel (literally *the house of Joseph*) was dominated by the tribes of Joseph's sons, Ephraim and Manasseh (see study note on 5:15; see [Hos 5:3, 5](#)).

Amos 5:8-9

Amos quotes a second hymn fragment (see [4:13](#); [9:5-6](#)). Once again, the prophet emphasizes the contrast between the cosmic God and the local gods. • Stars, celestial bodies, and constellations such as Pleiades and Orion were regarded as deities in the ancient world. Not so, says Amos; the Lord made them and placed them in the sky. • water: The ancients had observed a process that they did not understand (evaporation and condensation). However, the Lord understands and controls natural processes that seem mysterious to humans.

Amos 5:10

Amos resumes the thought begun in [5:7](#). Israel's courts, controlled by the wealthy, depended on corrupt judges and hired witnesses. They had no use for what was true, but only for what was expedient to their own cause ([5:12](#)).

Amos 5:11

stone houses: Again, Amos targets the rich. The houses of peasants were built of mud brick. Cut stone, the result of laborious handwork, was very expensive.

Amos 5:13

Witnesses pleaded that they saw and heard nothing. Truthfulness had become a liability ([5:10](#)) and might endanger the one who spoke it.

Amos 5:14

Amos makes his earlier hints ([5:4](#), [6](#)) more explicit: Israel must do what is good and right in order to survive.

Amos 5:15

the remnant of his people: The Hebrew text uses *the remnant of Joseph* to refer to the northern kingdom, who were still God's people despite their rebellion and idolatry.

Amos 5:16

farmers . . . professional mourners: This expression is a graphic way of describing that everyone would grieve.

Amos 5:16–17

crying . . . mourning . . . wailing: Grief would result from the widespread and certain destruction that lay ahead ([5:1–2](#)).

Amos 5:18

Amos again confronts the Israelites' distorted view of their chosen status (see [3:2](#)). • The phrase What sorrow awaits you denotes despair brought on by a great tragedy. • The day of the Lord in the Old Testament (see [Isa 13:6, 9](#)) was a time when God would intervene in the world to set right those things that had gone wrong. God's intervention would mean vindication for the righteous, but judgment for the wicked. Israel thought that on that day (see also [Amos 8:3, 9, 13; 9:11](#)) God would save them. However, because the Israelites had been wicked, the day of the Lord would bring darkness, not light. Assyria conquered the northern kingdom in 722 BC ([2 Kgs 17:7–23](#)), fulfilling this prophecy.

Amos 5:18–6.14

The pronouncements of sorrow in this section develop two themes: (1) Israel's apostasy would make the "day of the Lord" a day of judgment, not salvation; and (2) Judah's spiritual complacency would also bring judgment.

Amos 5:21–27

Amos again confronts the religious hypocrisy and spiritual unfaithfulness of the Israelites (see [4:4–5; Isa 1:10–20](#)).

Amos 5:22

God would not accept the offerings (see [Lev 1–6](#)) of the Israelites because they were attempts to manipulate him magically rather than signs of true repentance and faith.

Amos 5:24

This is the second of the great thematic verses in Amos (see [4:12](#)). • endless river: The streams or gullies (wadis) in Israel's dry areas contained water only temporarily during rainy seasons. However, God wanted continual, not just seasonal, justice.

Amos 5:25

Israel's relationship with God was based on true devotion that yielded obedience ([1 Sam 15:22-23](#)). Sacrifices representing repentance and faith could repair a breach made by sin, but they were not a substitute for a life lived in accordance with God's word. • Forty years in the wilderness was the duration of Israel's wandering after the rebellion at Kadesh-barnea (see [Num 14:32-35](#)).

Amos 5:25-26

Although the people of Israel claimed that God had to bless them because of the Sinai covenant, Amos demonstrated that they had been fundamentally pagan from the very earliest days of the covenant.

Amos 5:26-27

The names that appear in [5:26](#) have given rise to several conjectures, but many interpreters consider them to be names of unidentified pagan gods. The king god may well be Molech, god of the Ammonites (see [1:15](#)). The word translated you served may mean *you will lift up*, in which case the prophet is making a contrast between Israel or Judah, who carried their idols, and God, who carries his people (see [Isa 46:1-7](#)).

Amos 6:1

Jerusalem . . . Samaria: A message including Jerusalem is unexpected, but it shows that God plays no favorites; whoever rebels against God will experience sorrow. The Hebrew text uses the terms *Zion . . . Mount Samaria*, indicating the citadels of the two cities. The people of both Judea and Israel were smug and self-important, believing that the fortresses of the cities of Jerusalem and Samaria were impregnable (see also [4:3](#)). Relying on physical power instead of on God is sin.

Amos 6:2

Calneh and Hamath were Aramean city-states under Israelite influence (see [2 Kgs 14:28](#)). Calneh fell to Assyria in 738 BC, and Hamath was forced to pay tribute shortly thereafter. Uzziah had broken down the wall of Gath ([2 Chr 26:6](#)), but it also fell

to Assyria in 711 BC. • You are no better: Israel itself fell in 722 BC.

Amos 6:3

day of judgment (literally *seat of violence*): By this phrase, Amos either meant that Israel's behavior hastened the violence of the Assyrian conquest, or that the people encouraged everyday violence against the poor by pushing the thought of coming disaster from their minds.

Amos 6:4

Meat was typically used to honor distinguished guests. The common food was bread, fruit, vegetables, and dairy products. The everyday use of meat shows the opulence of the wealthy classes.

Amos 6:5-6

These verses provide a picture of drunken revelry.

Amos 6:6

wine by the bowlful: The word translated *bowl* (Hebrew *mizraq*) is related to a verb meaning *sprinkle* or *splash* (Hebrew *zaraq*; see [Exod 24:6](#)); the same word identified the basins used for sprinkling blood or water in religious ceremonies (see [2 Kgs 12:13](#); [25:15](#)), adding a sense of sacrilege to this description of their drunkenness. • of your nation: The Hebrew text reads *of Joseph*, referring to the northern kingdom of Israel; see study note on Amos 5:6.

Amos 6:8

The most solemn oath the Lord could pronounce was by his own name (see also [Gen 22:16](#); [Jer 51:14](#); cp. [Amos 4:2](#); [Ps 110:4](#); [Heb 6:13-14](#)). • arrogance of Israel (literally *pride of Jacob*; see study note on Amos 8:7): *Jacob* can mean *cheat* ([Gen 27:36](#)), whereas *Israel* means *he struggles with God* ([Gen 32:28](#)). Amos uses *Jacob* to express the obstinate arrogance that so often characterized the people of Israel.

Amos 6:9–10

These verses graphically picture the wholesale slaughter by military conquest promised in [6:8](#).

Amos 6:10

to dispose of the dead: Or *to burn the dead*. Cremation was very uncommon in the ancient Near East (see study note on [2:1](#)), so some interpret this phrase to mean *burn a memorial fire* (see [Jer 34:5](#)). Others take it to mean *dispose of the remains*, rather than perform a cremation. Yet the context—the need to dispose of multiple bodies to avoid putrefaction and disease ([Amos 6:9](#); see [8:3](#))—supports the idea that it means cremation.

Amos 6:12

It would be foolish to run horses . . . over boulders, because unshod horses cannot run on rocks without serious damage to their hooves. It is also obvious that oxen cannot plow rocks. A slight adjustment to the word division of the Hebrew text yields *plow the sea with oxen*, an equally absurd suggestion. • that's how foolish you are: The point of the comparisons now becomes obvious, as Israel's own absurdity surfaces in the moral realm. • you turn justice into poison: The people perverted what is just and right, turning it into something toxic and bitter (see also [5:7](#)).

Amos 6:13

Lo-debar and Karnaim that were part of the territory regained from the Arameans by Jeroboam II ([2 Kgs 14:25–28](#)). Amos makes puns on their names (see NLT textual footnote).

Amos 6:14

Lebo-hamath marked the northern border of Solomon's influence ([1 Kgs 8:65](#)) and of the land recovered by Jeroboam II. The Dead Sea (called the sea of the Arabah; see footnote on [2 Kgs 14:25](#)) marked the southern border of Jeroboam's recovered territory. The irony was clear: All of this recovered land would be oppressed by the enemy nation (Assyria).

Amos 7:1

Locusts (see [4:9](#)) were one of the plagues brought upon Egypt ([Exod 10:4](#)). Great swarms of locusts periodically invaded these lands, typically in times of drought. • king's share: The first harvest went to the king as taxes, whereas the later harvest of the main crop fed the farmer and his family. However, if locusts devoured this crop, starvation would follow.

Amos 7:1–6

The first two visions set up a mood of hopeful expectancy. God calls for judgment but then revokes it at the prophet's intercession.

Amos 7:1–9.10

This section contains five visions. It is helpful to compare the progression of these five visions with the judgments listed in [4:6–11](#) (famine, drought, crop devastation, plagues, destruction).

Amos 7:2

Israel is so small: The population base of the kingdom was not large enough to survive such radical depletion.

Amos 7:3–6

The Lord relented twice in response to Amos's intercession.

Amos 7:4

This fire symbolizes oppressive heat and drought. • depths of the sea: Although the Hebrew word properly indicates the sea, Amos probably did not suppose that the Mediterranean would disappear. More likely, this is a poetic reference to large bodies of fresh water (such as the Kinnereth Sea/Sea of Galilee) that Israel could use to irrigate its fields.

Amos 7:7-9

This vision begins like the previous two ([7:2-3](#), [4-6](#)), but this time the Lord allows no intercession. The abrupt shift in outcome contributed to the power of Amos's message.

Amos 7:8

The Hebrew word translated plumb line (Hebrew 'anak) is similar to the word for groaning ('anakhah, see [Isa 35:10](#); [Lam 1:22](#)), alluding to great suffering when God would hold Israel accountable.

Amos 7:9

pagan shrines . . . temples: Every vestige of the apostate Israelite religion, from the common high places to the royal shrine at Bethel, would be destroyed. • of your ancestors (literally *of Isaac*): Isaac stands for Israel's ancestors, the fathers of the nation. • dynasty of King Jeroboam: Jeroboam II died of natural causes ([2 Kgs 14:29](#)), but the murder of his son and successor, Zechariah, after a reign of less than a year ([2 Kgs 15:8-10](#); see [2 Kgs 10:28-31](#)), initiated instability in Israel's government that it never overcame ([2 Kgs 15:10-31](#)).

Amos 7:10-17

This section graphically depicts the corruption of the priesthood, reinforcing the point of the visions on either side of it, that judgment is inescapable.

Amos 7:11

Amaziah misinterpreted Amos's words as a threat on Jeroboam's life. Amos was calling the people to repentance, not sedition.

Amos 7:12

Go on back to . . . Judah, and earn your living by prophesying: Amaziah assumed that the supposedly backward people of Judah would appreciate Amos's words, and that Amos was looking to be paid for his preaching.

Amos 7:13

king's sanctuary: According to Amaziah, the urbane and sophisticated Israelites did not appreciate the prophet. Amaziah's loyalties were clearly to the throne; he wanted to keep the king happy in order to keep his job.

Amos 7:14

Amos was not a professional prophet or even a disciple in training. He had no financial incentive to leave his livelihood in order to prophesy. • shepherd: The Hebrew word here is not the same as in [1:1](#) and is not found elsewhere in the Old Testament. It is related to a word for cattle, suggesting that Amos may have raised cattle as a breeder or herder (see Amos Book Introduction, "The Prophet Amos"). • The sycamore-fig was gathered for cattle feed.

Amos 7:15

Amos was not motivated by financial gain. Instead, the Lord's voice (see [1:2](#); [3:8](#)) moved Amos to prophesy.

Amos 7:16

against my people (literally *against the house of Isaac*): Isaac represents all Israel (see also study note on 7:9; cp. [5:6](#), [15:6](#)).

Amos 7:17

Because Amaziah had tried to silence Amos ([7:12-13](#)), the Lord confronted Amaziah with a grim prophecy of what his life would be like after the Assyrian siege.

Amos 8:1

This vision resumes the prophetic sermon begun in [7:1](#) and interrupted by the dialogue with Amaziah.

Amos 8:2

ripe for punishment (literally *the end has come*): Amos makes a play on words between ripe fruit (Hebrew *qayits*) and *the end has come* (Hebrew *ba' haqqets*). The end had come for God's people, Israel, because they were ripe fruit, ready to be harvested in judgment.

Amos 8:4-14

This section expands the indictments and judgments listed earlier (read with [2:6-6:14](#)).

Amos 8:5

Work was explicitly forbidden on the Sabbath day ([Exod 20:9-10](#)); Amos implies that shops were closed during pagan new-moon religious festivals as well. • Merchants were cheating their customers by measuring grain with small ephahs and cheating their suppliers by using heavy shekels on the scales. This practice was forbidden by God's law ([Lev 19:35-36](#); [Deut 25:13-16](#); see [Prov 11:1](#); [16:11](#); [20:10](#), [23](#)).

Amos 8:7

the Pride of Israel: The same Hebrew phrase alludes in [6:8](#) to Israel's arrogance. Here, the phrase is probably a name for God, who is the legitimate object of Israel's pride. Elsewhere ([Ps 47:4](#); [Nah 2:2](#)), this phrase refers to the Promised Land under a king from David's line (cp. [Jer 13:9](#); [Ezek 32:12](#)). If the phrase here means the land, it would spotlight Israel's perverse pride in its national and geographic identity.

Amos 8:9

The day of the Lord would invert the cosmos. Jeremiah used similar imagery to describe the desecration of Judah as the Babylonian armies approached ([Jer 4:23](#); see also [Isa 13:10](#); [34:4](#); [50:3](#); [Ezek 32:7-8](#); [Joel 2:10](#), [31](#); [Mic 3:6](#)).

Amos 8:11-14

famine . . . of hearing the words of the Lord: God sent prophets to Israel to speak his words directly to them, but Israel commanded the prophets not to prophesy ([2:11-12](#)). Now they had what they wanted, but it was a silence more terrible than his roar and thunder: God became distant (see [Ezek 7:26](#); [20:3](#); [Mic 3:4](#), [7](#)). The time for speaking was over; the time of judgment had come.

Amos 8:12

from border to border: The natural boundaries of Israel were from sea to sea: the Mediterranean Sea on the west and the Dead Sea on the east. The other borders are simply called the *north* and the *east*.

Amos 8:14

The god of Dan refers to the northern shrine of the gold calf established by Jeroboam I (see [1 Kgs 12:28-29](#); [2 Kgs 10:29](#)). • the god of Beersheba: Evidently Beersheba had become a center of worship in the southern kingdom. Archaeologists have found the remains of a horned altar in the ruins of Beersheba.

Amos 9:1

I saw . . . the Lord (see [7:1](#)): God ceased to reveal how or why he would punish Israel; he was now poised to act. • beside the altar: Judgment must begin with the center of worship (cp. [1 Pet 4:17](#)). This altar probably refers to the Bethel shrine, although it could refer to the Temple in Jerusalem.

Amos 9:2

to the place of the dead (literally *to Sheol*): In the Old Testament, Sheol is a place beneath the earth where the dead have their abode.

Amos 9:2-4

God is inescapable (cp. [Ps 139:7-12](#)). When people trust, believe, and obey God, his inescapability is a great blessing. But because Israel rejected God's

revelation, his presence would mean judgment, not comfort.

Amos 9:3

Though Mount Carmel is not the highest mountain in the region, its lofty grandeur often represents the beauty and richness of the land. • sea serpent: In the ancient Near East, the sea was a symbol of chaos, often pitted against the national god (cp. [Pss 74:14; 89:10; 104:26](#)). However, the biblical text does not grant divine status to the sea monster (“Leviathan,” also called “Rahab”; [Ps 89:9–10](#)) but sees it as subject to the Lord’s command and judgment ([Isa 27:1](#)). Here, Amos portrays God’s sovereign power to summon the sea serpent to his service.

Amos 9:5–6

Amos uses a third hymn fragment (also [4:13; 5:8–9](#)) to remind Israel that God’s domain is universal.

Amos 9:7

the Ethiopians (literally *the Cushites*): Cush (see [Gen 10:6–7](#)) was south of the Second Cataract of the Nile (cp. [Isa 18:1](#)) and was often linked with Egypt, its neighbor to the north. • Israel’s exodus out of Egypt is compared to two other ancient migrations: the Philistines from Crete (see also [Jer 47:4](#)) and the Arameans out of Kir (cp. [Amos 1:5; 2 Kgs 16:9](#)).

Amos 9:8

Although God would severely punish Israel by uprooting and scattering them, he would never completely destroy them. A remnant would always exist.

Amos 9:9–10

Even the Lord’s most severe judgment is just. Only the sinners are destroyed, but not one true kernel will be lost; God will save the righteous, who are faithful to him.

Amos 9:11–12

Amos portrays true worship of God as built around the Jerusalem Temple, with a descendant of David ruling over a united kingdom including both Israel and Judah (cp. [Isa 9:6–7; 11:1–5](#)).

Amos 9:11–15

As the prophets often did, Amos closes his litany of judgments with a message of hope and restoration. Though Jerusalem and its Temple would be destroyed, David’s line of kings cut off ([Ps 89:38–51](#)), and its people taken into captivity, God would restore a remnant of Israel (see also [Isa 2:2–4; 4:2; 11:1–5](#)).

Amos 9:12

Edom (see [1:11](#)) represents the enemies of God and of Israel (see [Isa 34:5–6, 11; 63:1](#)). In the time of restoration, God’s enemies are subject to his people and to God himself. • the nations I have called: God promised Abraham that he would be a blessing to all the people of the earth ([Gen 12:2–3](#)). God’s kingdom would embrace the outcasts and foreigners previously excluded ([Isa 56](#); see [Acts 8:27–39](#)).

Amos 9:13

the hills . . . will drip with sweet wine: Amos points poetically to a future time when humans would once again live in harmony with God’s creation.

Amos 9:13–15

The coming age would restore the natural harmony lost in Eden ([Gen 3](#)) and would bring a new era of prosperity.

Amos 9:14–15

God promised not to completely destroy his people ([9:8](#)) but to bring the surviving remnant back to the land (see [Hos 2:23](#)).